Having briefed to him about the progress our team had made, Dhawan in early 1978 asked me if I needed to stay back in France longer or come back. I had a five-year mandate in France, but with the know-how and know-why we had acquired, I was eager to get back to India and start work on Vikas. There was still no project to develop the engine, but I had charted out my agenda. One, to identify a place to set up a facility for liquid propulsion and start working on Vikas. Two, to get Vikas into the PSLV that has been on the drawing board before I left for Vernon. PSLV, again, was not yet a project, but I know the launch vehicle should be powered by a liquid propulsion engine.

I didn't share these plans yet with Dhawan, but told him that it's time for me to get back to Trivandrum. A Chandran, who took over the three-tonne engine from where I left at the Sriharikota test site, now replaced me at Vernon. I packed my bags in March 1978.